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IN APRIL 1962 KHRUSHCHEV FOUND HIMSELF SIMULTANEOUSLY besieged by a number of foreign policy crises. First there was Castro's sudden turn against the communists in his government and threat of a new invasion of the island. Then came news that Kennedy had resumed atmospheric nuclear testing—a nuclear bomb was exploded at Christmas Island in the Pacific on April 25. It was a response to Soviet tests conducted in the fall of the previous year. That month Khrushchev fired the commander in chief of the Soviet Strategic Missile Forces, Marshal Kirill Moskalenko, who was blamed for allowing the real missile gap between the US and the USSR to increase.[4]

Marshal Moskalenko became the first victim of the American missile called "Minuteman." This was a new type of land-based intercontinental ballistic missile, powered by solid fuel and, unlike earlier liquid-fueled missiles that needed hours of fueling before a strike, could be ready at any minute—hence the name. Moreover, the Minuteman could be housed in silos hard for the enemy to destroy, making them almost impregnable. The USSR had nothing comparable to the Minuteman, because its missiles ran on liquid fuel and needed hours of prestrike fueling on open pads, making them vulnerable to enemy attack.[5]

Work on rockets powered by solid fuel began in the United States before 1957, but it was Sputnik that alerted Congress to the need to speed up the project. In 1958 the Minuteman development budget was almost quadrupled from $40 million to $150 million, and in 1959 it was further increased by $2 billion. By 1960 twelve thousand engineers and workers had been employed by Boeing alone to work on the Minuteman construction line in northern Utah. The first successful test of the new missile was conducted at Cape Canaveral, Florida, in February 1961. Construction of the first Minuteman missile field began in Montana in March. The Kennedy administration favored the Minuteman over other missile projects: expensive to design, it was relatively cheap to produce. By March 1962 American newspapers were writing about new rockets capable of delivering "one megaton of death and destruction."[6]